

What Your Groom Should Know.

The practical guide for the other half of the wedding.
What to wear, how to prepare, and what to do on the day.

- Why this actually matters — and what's at stake.
- What to wear — suit, fit, color, and details.
- Grooming — timing and what shows on camera.
- Getting ready coverage — what to have ready.
- Your role in portraits — how to show up.
- Following direction — what the photographer needs from you.
- Your wedding day timeline — the groom's version.

NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

"Genuine. Intentional. Timeless."

nydamphoto.com · Austin, Texas · Est. 2008

A NOTE TO THE GROOM

You're in More Photos Than You Think.

And your preparation is half of how they turn out.

*“After 18 years of weddings, I can tell you: the grooms who read the guide
and the grooms who don’t — it shows in the images.”*

ARLEN NYDAM · NYDAM PHOTOGRAPHY

This guide is short and direct because that’s how most grooms prefer information. It covers everything you need to know to show up prepared, look like yourself at your best, and make the portrait session easier and better for both of you.

The wedding photography conversation tends to focus almost entirely on the bride. But roughly half of every wedding portrait involves you. Your suit, your grooming, your posture, your hands, your expression — all of it is in the frame. Preparation is not optional if you care about the outcome.

You don’t need to enjoy being photographed. You don’t need to have opinions about photography. You need to read this guide, do the preparation it describes, and follow direction on the day. That’s it. We handle everything else.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- 01 What to Wear →
- 02 Grooming →
- 03 Getting Ready Coverage →
- 04 Your Role in Portraits →
- 05 Following Direction →
- 06 Your Wedding Day Timeline →

01

What to Wear.

The camera sees everything. Fit, fabric, color, and condition all read on camera in ways they don't in a mirror. Here is what to know and what to do before the wedding day.

THE SUIT OR TUXEDO

+ Fit is everything.

A well-fitted suit at any price point looks better on camera than an expensive suit that doesn't fit. Get it tailored. Jacket, trousers, and shirt — all three. This is not optional for wedding photography.

+ Jacket length and shoulder fit first.

The jacket shoulder seam should sit at your shoulder point, not beyond it. The jacket hem should cover your seat. These two things determine whether the suit looks like yours or borrowed. Get them right first.

+ Trouser break: minimal.

A slight break or no break at all photographs cleanest. Heavy breaks bunch at the ankle and draw the eye down in standing portraits. Shorter, cleaner, more modern.

+ Shirt collar and cuffs.

The shirt collar should sit close to the neck without being tight. Check that collar stays are in place on the day. Shirt cuffs should show ¼ to ½ inch below the jacket sleeve. This detail is visible in almost every portrait.

+ Color: dark, medium, or deliberate.

Navy, charcoal, and black photograph with the most versatility against any venue or background. Lighter colors work with the right venue and light. Check how your suit color reads against your partner's gown color — contrast is generally better than matching.

+ Tie or no tie — decide early.

Either is fine photographically. What matters is that the decision is made in advance and the accessories are complete. A tie with an undone top button looks intentional. A missing tie that was planned reads as forgotten.

+ Shoes: clean and polished.

Shoe condition is visible in portrait shots, walking shots, and any seated pose. Polish them the day before, not the morning of. Scuffed shoes in an otherwise excellent image are one of the most common regrets grooms mention.

+ Pocket square and boutonniere.

The pocket square adds visual structure to the jacket. Have it folded and placed before the photographer arrives. The boutonniere should be pinned straight. Both will be in close-up detail shots.

02

Grooming.

The camera is at close range for much of the wedding day. Grooming details that are invisible from across a room are visible in a portrait. Time these correctly.

Haircut: 7–10 days before.

Not the day before, not the morning of. 7–10 days gives the cut time to settle so it looks intentional, not fresh. Day-of haircuts look day-of in photographs.

Beard: trimmed and shaped.

If you wear a beard, have it shaped 2–3 days before — same logic as the haircut. Clean neckline, defined edges. A groomed beard photographs as a deliberate choice. An untrimmed beard photographs as neglect.

Clean shave: the morning of.

If you're shaving clean, shave on the morning of the wedding. Not the night before. A close shave looks best on camera in the hours after it happens.

Skin: moisturize the week before.

Dry, rough skin reads on camera in close-up shots. Basic daily moisturizer in the week before the wedding makes a visible difference in portrait detail shots. Not complicated. Just consistent.

Nails: clean and trimmed.

Your hands are in the frame in almost every portrait — holding your partner's hands, on her waist, in ring detail shots. Clean, trimmed nails. No rough edges. Have this done 1–2 days before.

Eyebrows: if they're prominent.

If your eyebrows are naturally heavy or unruly, a quick clean-up 3–5 days before makes a difference. Not shaped — just managed. This is a five-minute task with a visible payoff.

Sunburn: avoid it.

A fresh sunburn on the face or neck photographs as uneven red skin tone and distracts from everything else. In the week before the wedding, wear sunscreen outdoors. Texas sun in spring and fall is still strong enough to burn.

Glasses: clean the lenses.

If you wear glasses, clean the lenses the morning of and carry a cloth. Smudged lenses in close-up portraits are one of the most common and easiest-to-avoid problems.

Fragrance: wear what you always wear.

Not the place for something new. Wearing a familiar scent keeps you feeling like yourself, which shows in your expression and ease in front of the camera.

GROOMING RULE

Haircut 7–10 days before. Nails 1–2 days before. Shave the morning of.

03

Getting Ready Coverage.

Getting ready photography for grooms is shorter and less complex than for brides. But the images from this part of the morning are among the most used from the entire wedding day. A few things to have in order.

WHAT TO HAVE READY

+ Suit hung, not on the floor.

Your suit should be hanging on a hanger — jacket, trousers, and shirt — when the photographer arrives. Not in a bag on the floor, not draped over a chair. Hung, visible, and wrinkle-free.

+ Shoes out and polished.

Shoes on the floor or a surface where they can be photographed. Shine them the night before. Detail shots of shoes, cufflinks, and accessories happen early while the room is still clean.

+ Watch, cufflinks, and accessories organized.

On a tray, a nightstand, or any clean surface. Not scattered. Not in pockets. These are detail shot items and they photograph best when arranged.

+ Boutonniere accessible.

Know where it is and who is pinning it. The boutonniere pinning is a photographed moment — typically a parent or best man. Have it out and ready when that moment approaches.

+ Ring accessible.

Your ring is a detail shot item. Have it out where it can be photographed — ideally with your partner's ring together, on a clean surface or on the invitation. Tell us where it is when we arrive.

+ One clean, uncluttered space.

The getting ready room does not need to be hotel-magazine clean. It needs one clear area — where the suit is hanging, where the details are laid out — with no visual clutter behind it. Move bags and beer bottles out of frame before the photographer arrives.

+ Have your groomsmen dressed or close to it.

Getting ready images work best when the room has energy — people in various states of getting dressed, the natural activity of the morning. If everyone is already fully dressed and seated, that energy is gone.

+ Know your timeline.

Know what time you need to be dressed, what time the ceremony starts, and what time any first look or pre-ceremony portraits are scheduled. The photographer works to your timeline. You need to know what it is.

04

Your Role in Portraits.

Couple portraits are 20–30 minutes of your wedding day. What you do in that time — specifically how you hold your partner, where you put your hands, and how present you are — determines the quality of images you will both look at for the rest of your lives.

HOW TO SHOW UP

+ Be the stable one.

Your partner will be managing the gown, the veil, the emotions, and the biggest day of her life simultaneously. Your job in portraits is to be calm, steady, and present. That quality shows in every image.

+ Hold her like you mean it.

A hand placed deliberately on her waist communicates confidence. A hand hovering near her shoulder communicates uncertainty. Place your hands with intention. The difference is visible on camera every single time.

+ Chin forward and down.

The chin trick applies to you as much as to her. Push the chin slightly forward and down — not up, not back. It defines the jaw and prevents the shadow under the chin that makes everyone feel self-conscious about their photos. Practice in a mirror. It takes two minutes to learn.

+ Shoulders back and down.

Drop your shoulders before every shot. Not military posture — just consciously relaxed. Rolled or raised shoulders read as tense on camera. A breath out and a shoulder drop changes the entire frame.

+ Be genuinely present with her.

The expression on your face when you look at your partner cannot be faked and cannot be directed into existence. What it can do is appear naturally when you are actually present — looking at her, not past her. This is the only instruction that requires nothing physical.

+ Follow direction immediately.

When we give a direction — step in closer, put your hand here, look at her — execute it immediately and completely. Not almost. Tentative compliance produces tentative images. Full compliance with direction is the groom's most important contribution.

+ Keep the energy up.

Portrait sessions can feel awkward at the start. Your energy — relaxed, engaged, willing to commit — sets the tone for both of you. If you're visibly tolerating the process, it shows in every image. If you're present and engaged, that shows too.

+ Don't check the images mid-session.

If we show you an image, it's for your feedback. Otherwise — stay in the session. Breaking the energy to review images costs more time than it saves and breaks your partner's momentum.

05 + 06

Direction & Your Timeline.

What to do when the photographer is working — and how the wedding day actually flows from the groom's perspective.

FOLLOWING DIRECTION

- + **When we say closer, go closer.**
The most common adjustment in couple portraits is closing distance. It always feels closer than it looks. Do it without negotiating.
- + **When he gives a prompt, commit to it.**
Whisper something in her ear. Spin her. Walk toward the camera. Do these things completely — not halfway. Half-committed movement produces half-usable images.
- + **Trust the process.**
Some prompts will feel awkward. Follow them anyway. We've used these prompts across hundreds of weddings. The feeling of awkwardness in the moment and the quality of the image are not correlated.
- + **If something feels wrong, say so.**
If a pose is physically uncomfortable, say so. If you need a moment, say so. What you should not do is silently endure something that affects your expression and energy.

YOUR WEDDING DAY TIMELINE

- + **Getting ready: 60–90 min with photographer.**
we arrive while you're still dressing. Have the suit hung and details ready before he walks in.
- + **First look (if applicable): 20–30 min.**
Private portraits before the ceremony. The most relaxed and genuine couple images of the day happen here, before the crowd and timeline pressure.
- + **Ceremony: be unreachable.**
Do not check your phone in the 30 minutes before the ceremony. Be mentally present before you are physically present at the altar.
- + **Family formals: 20–30 min post-ceremony.**
Know the family list in advance. Brief your family: stay near the altar, don't disappear to cocktail hour. Cooperative families cut this time in half.
- + **Couple portraits: protect the window.**
20–45 minutes. Talk to your coordinator about protecting this time. It is the one part of the day most likely to get compressed by timeline pressure from everywhere else.
- + **Golden hour: worth staying for.**
If your venue and timeline allow for outdoor portraits in the 30–60 minutes before sunset — plan for it. These are often the best images of the day.

About Nydam Photography.

We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every session we do is personal. We arrive prepared — every session planned with intention — and we create something real.

We photograph with natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors — because the quality of the image matters more than the convenience of the approach. Every image is considered. Every detail is intentional.

GENUINE

Every portrait should feel like you — not a polished version of someone else. We create the conditions for real moments, then capture them.

INTENTIONAL

Light, posing, expression, timing — every element of a great portrait is considered in advance and guided with care throughout.

TIMELESS

We edit for longevity, not for trends. The images we create together are meant to stop you in your tracks ten years from now.

Weddings · Families & Portraits · Seniors · Sacraments · Quinceañeras · Events · Sports · Corporate Headshots & Branding

Every specialty. One standard of care.

KNOW SOMEONE WHO DESERVES THIS?

Pass this guide along — or send them directly to us. The right photographer changes everything. If you found yours — share that gift. A referral from a client is the highest compliment we receive.

With warmth,

Arlen and Tanya Nydam, Nydam Photography

nydamphoto.com · arlen.nydam@gmail.com